

Henry Alfred Kissinger was a controversial public figure who divided opinion: to some, he was a visionary strategist executing a grand design; to others, he was at best inflexible and obsessed with details, or, far worse, a warmonger guilty of war crimes, especially for his role in the bombing of Cambodia.

Kissinger did not work his way up through the ranks, but went straight to the top, due to his skills as a policy analyst—and by the judicious cultivation of patrons. As the adviser of presidents and politicians, he was widely viewed as an operator: a man who identified a goal and then sought to achieve it through a series of discrete maneuvers.